

What were the major factors leading to the decline in authority of the Later Mughals? Elaborate on the role played by power struggles among nobles and the administrative inefficiencies during this period. [10 marks]

3) The 18th century India was not merely a decline in the authority of Mughals but also disintegrated a once powerful centrally controlled Mughal India by Aurangzeb.

Factors leading to the decline of Mughal India

- ① No clear line of succession in later Mughals and often killings within the family became the "new normal" which led to the Mughal emperors turning into "puppet rulers".
- ② Many Mughal emperors after 1707 ascended^{to} the throne with the help of nobles, this led to the transfer of powerful administrative posts such as "Wazir" and "Mir Bakshi" to the nobles.
- ③ Invasions by the Persian rulers such as Nadir Shah, Ahmed Shah Abdali, Ghulam Qadir catalysed the fragmentation of Mughal empire.

through ~~the~~ by supporting regional powers such as Marathas in the battle of Panipat.

④ Due to the intervention of nobles such as Saiyyad brothers, Chauth and Sardesmukhi of Deccan was given to Marathas → Reducing the tax base of Mughal empire

So, the role of nobles from mere "Mansabdars" transformed into "King makers" which later went onto establish fully autonomous states like Hyderabad. The 18th century India not only saw the decline of Mughal authority but led to the disintegration of India and the consolidation of European colonialism.